

Title

Sustained Behaviour Change and Social Determinants in Cardiac Rehabilitation: A Qualitative Subgroup Analysis

Abstract

Secondary qualitative analysis examined how individual characteristics and life circumstances shaped rehabilitation engagement and physical activity maintenance. Participants with stronger pre-existing social networks reported greater perceived support for exercise continuation post-rehabilitation. Employment status and family care responsibilities emerged as significant contextual factors affecting availability for activity. Gender-based differences in motivation for lifestyle change were evident, with female participants emphasising health preservation whereas male participants emphasised functional capacity recovery. Participants expressing higher baseline exercise confidence demonstrated more independent engagement with activity outside supervised sessions. The behaviour change coaching group showed particular benefit among individuals who reported initial low confidence, suggesting that explicit skill-building supports may address specific barriers in this subset. Long-term follow-up data were limited, precluding assessment of sustained change beyond the rehabilitation period. Healthcare utilisation rates showed no meaningful differences between arms at intermediate time points. These findings suggest that future cardiac rehabilitation interventions should incorporate tailored approaches accounting for social context and baseline self-efficacy beliefs.